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Procedural Terrain Engine – Basin Detection & Hydrological Simulation System

Basin Detection System Overview

This module marks the transition from terrain generation to terrain intelligence. The engine no longer only creates terrain but begins to analyze its physical behavior, especially how water interacts with elevation structures.

<https://www.udemy.com/course/web-based-3d-terrain-industrial-printing-engine-mastery/>

System Role in Engine Architecture

Earlier systems focused on generating terrain, managing chunks, and rendering GPU meshes. This module introduces a new layer where terrain is interpreted as a physical simulation space capable of supporting hydrological reasoning.

Core Objective: Hydrological Reasoning

The system is designed to determine where water accumulates, how it flows, and whether it escapes or remains trapped. Terrain is now treated as a decision field for water movement rather than a static surface.

Local Minima Detection System

Local minima detection identifies terrain points that are lower than all surrounding neighbors. These points act as natural water collection centers and serve as seed nodes for basin formation and lake generation.

Flood-Fill Hydrological Simulation

Basin Classification Logic

Terrain regions are classified into closed basins and open basins. Closed basins trap water completely, while open basins allow drainage paths that lead outward, enabling river formation.

Basin Clustering and Region Graphs

Multiple nearby basins are merged into clustered hydrological regions. These clusters form graph structures representing terrain water retention and drainage networks.

Terrain to Hydrological Field Transformation

Terrain is no longer treated as geometry. It becomes a computational field that represents flow behavior, accumulation zones, and drainage logic across a continuous spatial system.

GPU and Performance Considerations

Basin detection requires grid-wide evaluation and recursive propagation. To maintain real-time performance, processing is divided into chunks and executed in parallel across GPU-friendly structures.

Full Hydrological Pipeline

The pipeline begins with heightmap input, continues with local minima detection, flood-fill expansion, boundary analysis, basin classification, and ends with hydrological map generation.

Engineering Interpretation Model

Terrain is interpreted as a graph system where local minima are attractor nodes and basins are equilibrium regions. Water behaves as a dynamic process navigating this graph structure.

System Behavior Outcome

The system gains the ability to evaluate water flow, detect basins, and simulate hydrological behavior in real time, enabling lakes, rivers, and erosion systems.

Student Questions

Why are local minima essential for hydrological simulation

Why is terrain modeled as a graph system here

Student Assignments

Implement local minima detection on a heightmap grid

Build a flood-fill water propagation system

Create a basin classification engine for open and closed regions

Design a clustering system for merging hydrological basins

Final Engine Statement

At this stage, terrain is no longer a visual mesh. It becomes a computational hydrological system capable of analyzing flow behavior, detecting structural depressions, and simulating water accumulation as part of a real-time environmental simulation engine.

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